

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NICARAGUA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to land, water, and sovereignty in Nicaragua, and one of the largest megaprojects ever proposed in the Americas was faced down, in large part, by farmers in rubber boots. In 2013, the government granted a Chinese company a fifty-year concession to cut a **Grand Interoceanic Canal** across the country — some two hundred and seventy-eight kilometres from the Pacific to the Caribbean, straight through **Lake Nicaragua**, the nation's great freshwater reserve — with sweeping powers to expropriate the land in its path. The people who lived on that land, campesinos in the country's centre and south, did not wait to be moved. Led by a farmer named **Francisca Ramírez**, they built the **National Council for the Defense of the Land, Lake and Sovereignty**, and over the following years they marched — roughly a hundred times — against the concession, alongside indigenous and Afro-descendant communities and a constitutional lawsuit brought by a lawyer and scores of plaintiffs. The canal was never built. Not a single stretch was dug, the concession was finally repealed in 2024, and the communities that would have been drowned or displaced are still on their land. The scale of what was faced down is worth setting down. The concession, passed as a law in a matter of days with almost no debate, handed a Hong Kong company a fifty-year term, extendable, and the power to take the land the route required; the projected cost was some fifty billion dollars, and a groundbreaking ceremony was held at the end of 2014. Yet the years passed and nothing was dug — no financing materialised, the company's founder saw his fortune collapse, and the great project that was to rival Panama came, in the end, to nothing. The communities in its path had refused to treat it as inevitable, and they were proved right.

The Nicaragua story teaches two things about defending land here — including its hard and painful limits, which this guide states from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected communities, the documentation, the coalition, the legal challenge, and the country's and the world's attention — pressed together. The second is distinctly Nicaraguan, and it rose from the furrows of the countryside. **A determined rural movement, joined with indigenous and Afro-descendant communities and framed around the defence of land, water, and national sovereignty, can deny a megaproject its legitimacy, protect the communities' claim to their ground, expose the project's weakness, and outlast it.** That power — the campesino march, the community assembly, the alliance across peoples, the sovereignty claim, the constitutional challenge — is Nicaragua's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. It is worth naming what made the anti-canal movement work, because it is instructive even now that its methods carry greater danger. It was rooted in the affected communities themselves, farmers who stood to lose the ground they lived on, rather than in a distant leadership; it built a broad front that reached from the Pacific campesinos to the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples of the Caribbean coast whose territories the route would cross; it framed its cause not merely as local grievance but as the defence of the nation's land, its great lake, and its sovereignty; and it paired the marches in the countryside with a constitutional lawsuit in the courts. That combination of the local and the national, the street and the law, is the template.

But the same story carries grave warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The canal's collapse owed as much to the **financial ruin of its foreign backer** as to the resistance — the movement kept the project contested and exposed, but it did not defeat it alone. And the price the movement paid was terrible: campesino leaders were **imprisoned, driven into exile, and killed**, especially after the events of 2018, and the civic space that once allowed a hundred marches has since **narrowed almost to nothing**. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a rural movement that defends its land and sovereignty — and the financier's collapse, the severe repression, and the closing of civic space that qualify it, and that mean the ways of fighting must now often be quieter, more documentary, more legal, and more international than the mass marches of the past. The repression that fell on the movement is part of its story and cannot be separated from it. When a broad civic uprising swept the country in 2018, many anti-canal campesinos took part, and the state's response was severe: leaders were jailed, others fled across the border into exile, and some were killed in the remote countryside. In the years since, independent organisations have been shut, the independent press has largely been forced abroad, and the space for the kind of open, sustained protest the movement once mounted has all but disappeared. A guide to resistance here must therefore teach not only how the movement won ground but how a community fights when that ground for protest is gone.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective, or how to adapt it when the space to protest closes. They face a concession or a project and assume "the powerful have decided and nothing can be done," and never document, never organise the community, never build the alliance, never mount the legal challenge, never reach the

world. They generate private loss without a public claim. The gap between a community that holds its ground and one that loses it is rarely courage — Nicaraguan campesinos have shown extraordinary courage at terrible cost. It is method: knowing how to organise, document, ally, and litigate, and how to keep fighting through the courts, the international bodies, and the diaspora when the streets are closed.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Nicaraguan system as it is, including when it is at its most closed.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a megaproject, a mine, or a concession over a community's land:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the rights, and the leverage)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build proof of the harm and the illegality)
|
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (organise the communities and the alliance)
|
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES (the constitution, the courts, and international bodies)
|
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the organised communities sustain the pressure; a legal challenge or an international appeal is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that endures — a project denied, delayed, exposed, or outlasted, and a community's claim to its land protected. The anti-canal movement did exactly this — it organised the campesinos, documented the threat, built an alliance across peoples, mounted a constitutional challenge, and carried its cause to the nation and the world.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Nicaragua's give communities a distinctive set — though several must now be used with great care:

- **Rural campesino mobilisation.** The **organised countryside** — the community assembly, the march, the roadblock — is a distinctive Nicaraguan force, though open protest now carries grave danger. Nicaragua has a deep tradition of rural organisation, of communities that meet, decide together, and act as one, and it was this tradition the anti-canal movement drew on when it organised roughly a hundred marches over several years, converging from scattered villages on the roads the canal would follow. That capacity to mobilise the countryside is a real and distinctive strength; but it must now be weighed against a danger it did not carry, or did not carry so heavily, in the years of the marches, and a community must judge with great care when and whether open action serves its cause or merely exposes its people.
- **The alliance across peoples.** Campesino, **indigenous, and Afro-descendant** communities united present a broad and legitimate front, as they did against the canal.
- **The sovereignty and anti-dispossession claim.** Defending **land, water, and national sovereignty** against a foreign concession is a powerful, unifying frame. This frame did particular work in the canal fight, because it lifted the struggle above the interests of any one village: a Nicaraguan who would never be touched by the canal could still be moved by the sight of the nation's land and its greatest lake being signed over to a foreign company for half a century, without the people being asked. Framing a local fight as a defence of the national patrimony — the land, the water, the sovereignty that belong to all — draws in support far beyond the affected communities and makes a project harder for any government to defend as being in the national interest.
- **The constitution and the courts.** A **constitutional challenge**, and the rights to consultation the constitution and international law affirm, are a real if constrained lever.
- **International and inter-American bodies.** When the domestic space closes, the **international and inter-American human-rights systems** and the **diaspora** become essential levers.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers safely stop projects. The canal's fall owed much to its **backer's collapse**. Open protest now brings **severe repression**. And the **civic space has closed** dramatically. This guide takes those limits with the utmost seriousness, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — organising where it is safe, documenting always, allying across peoples, litigating, and reaching the world, as the anti-canal movement reached it, while protecting the people who carry the fight.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the leverage — is weakest, and which levers are safe to use and which now carry danger.

The Levels of Decision

A Nicaraguan land or development question runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene — some more safely than others.

The government and the concession. The **national government** grants concessions, permits, and sweeping legal powers, often with little debate, as it granted the canal concession in days. This is usually the proponent, and the hardest and most dangerous level to confront directly.

The company. Foreign and domestic companies hold the concessions and build the projects — and, as the canal showed, a project can collapse on the company's own weakness, its financing, its competence. This is a lesson the canal drove home and one a community should never forget: the proponent's apparent power can mask a real fragility. The company behind the canal was presented as the vehicle of one of the richest men in the world, yet its financing was never secured, its founder's fortune proved fragile, and years after the ceremonial groundbreaking not a metre had been dug. A community that studies the proponent's money, its record, and its competence, rather than being cowed by its announcements, may find that the project is weaker than it looks and that time and exposure are on the community's side.

The communities and their land. The **campesino, indigenous, and Afro-descendant communities** hold the land, and, for indigenous and Afro-descendant territories, rights to **consultation and consent** the constitution and international law affirm — a real claim even when it is violated.

The courts. Nicaragua's **courts** are heavily constrained, but a **constitutional challenge** and a documented legal record still matter, at home and abroad.

The international level. When the domestic doors close, the **inter-American and international human-rights bodies**, and the **diaspora and international press**, become a level the community can still reach.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government **concession or permit**, through the **company** that would build it, over the **communities' land**, toward construction — with the **communities, the courts, and, increasingly, the international bodies and the diaspora** able to document, resist, and litigate at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in**, though some must now be approached with great care for the safety of those involved. The distinctive Nicaraguan doors are the **organised communities and their alliance**, and the **sovereignty and consultation claims**, which denied the canal its legitimacy. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **what rights the communities hold** and **where the project is weak** — its financing, its legality, its lack of consultation — because those are often where it can be stopped or outlasted.

Follow the Land, the Concession, and the Consultation

Behind a project stand a proponent — a company, the government, or both — and the officials who approved it. Trace who profits, who decided, and — critically in Nicaragua — **whose land is taken, whether the indigenous and Afro-descendant communities were consulted and consented, whether the concession is lawful, and what the project does to the land, the water, and the great lake**. Two questions unlock most Nicaraguan fights: **Was there lawful consultation and consent, and is the concession constitutional?** and **Where is the project weak — its money, its legality, its legitimacy — and how can the community outlast it while staying safe?** The rights and the weaknesses are, together, the heart of most Nicaraguan campaigns. The two reinforce one another in a particular way here: the rights — to consultation, to consent, to the land itself — give the fight its legitimacy and its legal and international footing, while the weaknesses — the shaky financing, the flawed legality, the bypassed process — give it the practical openings through which a project can be delayed, exposed, and outlasted. A campaign that presses the rights alone may be morally strong but slow; one that watches the weaknesses alone may miss the enduring legal claim; the canal fight did both, asserting the communities' rights while the project's own fragility undid it.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, constrained but not nothing; the **constitution and international law** on consultation and rights; the **inter-American and international human-rights systems**; **civil society, the church, and the universities**, though many are now under pressure; the **independent press and the diaspora**; and the **organised communities** themselves. In Nicaragua, the **organised communities and their alliance** are the most distinctive lever, and the **international and inter-american bodies** the most important when the domestic space closes. Each is a separate front, and a project that lacks lawful consultation, that rests on a questionable concession, that is weak in its own foundations, and that faces united communities and international scrutiny is a project that can be denied, exposed, and outlasted — as the canal was. You do not have to win on one front alone: the same documented record of the missing consultation and the project's weakness can go to the courts, the international bodies, the press, and the diaspora at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others and helps protect the people on the ground. A Nicaraguan campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together — the communities and their rights establishing the claim, the courts and international bodies recording the wrong, and the world and the diaspora carrying it beyond the state's reach — so that the fight survives even when the space at home is closed.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly — and in Nicaragua, calibrate for safety as well as success. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Nicaraguan and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **communities are organised and united**, whether the **alliance across peoples** holds, whether the **consultation and consent** were violated, whether the **concession is unlawful**, whether the **project is weak** in its own foundations, and, crucially now, whether the fight can be carried through the **courts, the international bodies, and the diaspora** when the streets are closed. Where the communities are united and the project is weak or unlawful, the Nicaraguan levers are real, as the canal showed; but temper every figure with the knowledge of the repression and the closed space, and with the honest truth that a project may fall as much on its own weakness as on the resistance.

Individual Step Success Rates

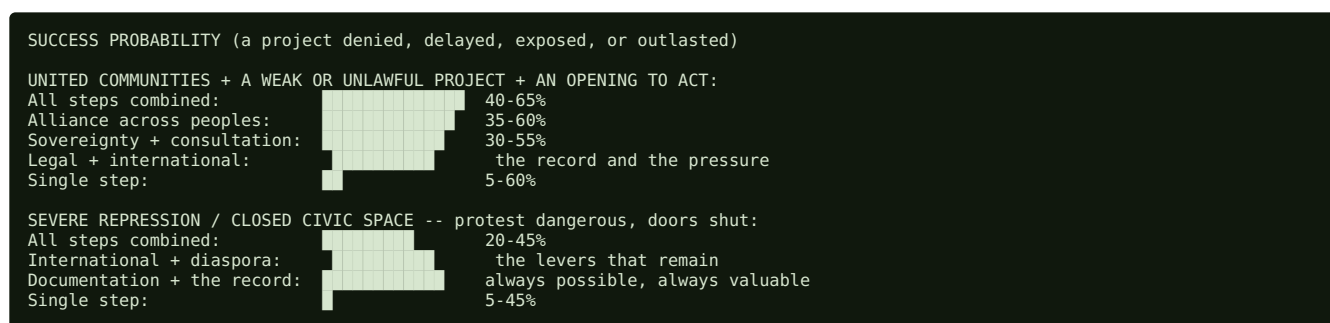
Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost / Risk	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Organised community mobilisation	30–55%	ongoing	low money / high risk now	Legitimacy denied; the project contested
Alliance across peoples	35–60%	varies	low	A broad, legitimate front
Sovereignty & anti-dispossession framing	30–55%	ongoing	low	The nation's sympathy; unity
Constitutional / legal challenge	15–40%	years	low-moderate	Delay; the record; the illegality shown
Consultation / consent claim	20–45%	years	low	A rights violation established
International & inter-American bodies	25–50%	years	low	Scrutiny, pressure, and the record when the domestic space is closed
Media & the world's attention	35–60%	ongoing	low	The nation and the world engaged
All steps (united communities, weak/unlawful project)	40–65%	months–years	low-moderate / manage risk	Denied, delayed, exposed, or outlasted
All steps (severe repression, closed space)	20–45%	years	low / high risk	The record, international pressure, and the claim protected

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Nicaragua's real strengths are distinctive — **organised communities**, the **alliance across peoples**, the **sovereignty and consultation claims**, the **legal challenge**, and, when the space closes, the **international bodies and the diaspora**. Its constraints are severe and specific: a project may fall on its **own weakness**; open protest brings **grave repression**; and the **civic space has closed**, so the fight must often be documentary, legal, and international.

A note on cost and risk: organising, documenting, allying, and litigating cost little money, and even the great anti-canal movement was carried by farmers of modest means. But in today's Nicaragua the cost is measured in risk, not money — the risk to those who protest and lead. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the unity of the communities and the persistence to carry the fight through every available channel — and, above all, the care to protect the people who

carry it.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Nicaragua are, in an opening, **the organised communities, the alliance, and the sovereignty and consultation claims**, amplified by the courts and the world; and, in a closure, the **international bodies, the diaspora, and the documentary record**. The canal shows the ceiling: united communities and a weak project, and the megaproject fell. But the repression shows the floor: the space that allowed a hundred marches has closed, and the fight must now often be quieter. Most Nicaraguan fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the communities and the alliance are powerful when they can act, that a project's own weakness can be decisive, and that when the streets close, the record, the courts, and the world are the levers that remain. Read the table, then, as a guide to matching your effort to your moment: in an opening, when action is possible and a project is weak or unlawful, a united movement can aim to deny, expose, and outlast it outright; in a closure, when the streets are shut, the realistic aims are the enduring record, the international vindication, and the protection of the claim and the people until a freer day. Knowing which moment you are in keeps a campaign both effective and safe, ambitious where it can be and careful where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The organised communities and the alliance across peoples** — Nicaragua's most distinctive lever; the united campesino, indigenous, and Afro-descendant front that denied the canal its legitimacy.
2. **The sovereignty, consultation, and consent claims** — the powerful frame and the real rights, violated by the canal, that unite the nation and ground the legal case.
3. **The legal challenge and the record** — the constitutional suit and the documented illegality that expose a project and endure, at home and before the world.
4. **International and inter-American bodies, and the diaspora** — the levers that carry the fight when the domestic space is closed.
5. **Media and the world's attention** — the coverage that engages the nation and the world and protects the people who resist.

What Nicaraguan Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **United communities can deny legitimacy** — the alliance made the canal a national controversy it never shook. **A weak project can fall on its own** — the canal's backer collapsed. **Consultation is a real right, and its violation a real claim** — the canal bypassed indigenous consent. **Repression is severe** — the movement paid in prison, exile, and blood. **The record and the world endure** — when the streets closed, the documentation and the international bodies carried on. The through-line: **organise and ally where you safely can; document always; ground the fight in sovereignty, consultation, and law; and carry it through the courts, the world, and the diaspora — because in Nicaragua a united people can outlast a project, but must protect itself as it does.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the rights the communities hold and the weaknesses the project carries, which in Nicaragua are often the missing consultation and the project's own fragility. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the concession that would flood our land and our lake, granted without consulting the indigenous communities it crosses" is a campaign — the campaign the anti-canal movement waged. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Whose land, and were they consulted? This is the first Nicaraguan question. Whose land does the project take, and were the **indigenous and Afro-descendant communities consulted and did they consent**, as the constitution and international law require? A project that bypassed consultation carries a real legal and moral flaw.

2. Where is the project weak? Is the project weak in its **financing, its competence, its legality, or its legitimacy**, as the canal was? A project's own fragility can be the community's greatest ally, so find it. A project's weakness is often the fastest route to stopping it, and it is worth investigating with real rigour, because a government can override a community's objection but cannot conjure financing that does not exist or competence a company lacks. Look hard at who is really paying, whether the money is committed or merely announced, whether the technical plans are sound, and whether the legal foundation would survive scrutiny — and where you find fragility, as the canal's opponents found it, understand that patient documentation and exposure may do what confrontation cannot.

3. What does it do to the land, the water, and the lake? What **harm** does the project cause — to the land, the water, the great lake, the forests, the communities — and what do the people stand to lose? Give particular weight to the great lake and the water, because in Nicaragua these carry a significance beyond the local: the country's largest lake is a national freshwater reserve and a source of deep public feeling, and a project that would threaten it can be opposed not only by those it displaces but by a nation that does not wish to see it harmed. Documenting the harm to the water and the lake, alongside the harm to the land and the forests, connects a community's particular loss to a patrimony the whole country has a stake in defending.

4. Can the alliance across peoples be built, safely? Can **campesino, indigenous, and Afro-descendant** communities unite behind the fight, and how can they organise while protecting those who lead, given the danger? This question must be asked honestly and early, because the answer shapes everything that follows: the same alliance that gives a movement its strength also concentrates risk on its leaders, and the history of the anti-canal movement, whose figures were imprisoned and exiled, is a warning that must be heeded. Plan from the outset for the protection of those who organise and testify — sharing leadership so no one person is indispensable, building ties abroad that can carry on if people inside are silenced, and weighing every visible action against the danger it brings — so that the movement can endure the repression that a serious challenge may provoke.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be reached? Which part of the government or which company is behind it, who profits; and which courts, international bodies, press, diaspora, and public can be engaged — especially those beyond the reach of domestic repression.

A Worked Example

Suppose a foreign-financed concession would cut across campesino and indigenous land and a great water body, and the communities were never consulted.

Working the five questions: whose **land**, and were the communities **consulted**? Where is the project **weak** — its money, its legality? What **harm** to the land and water? Can the **alliance** be built safely? And the deciders are the government and the company, with the communities, the courts, the international bodies, the press, and the diaspora as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will take our land" to a target list: document the missing consultation and the harm; find the project's weakness; build the alliance while protecting its people; mount the legal and international challenge; and carry the cause to the nation and the world. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how the anti-canal movement fought. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a frightening rumour that the land would be taken into a set of concrete, workable tasks — prove the missing consultation, find the project's weakness, unite the communities safely, mount the legal and international case — several of which can be pursued quietly, out of the reach of repression. That reframing, from dread to a plan that includes safe and enduring lines of attack, is the difference the five questions make in Nicaragua, where the ability to keep fighting without exposing people to danger is itself decisive.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and in Nicaragua, where the fight must often move from the streets to the courts and the international bodies, the record is more important than ever. A court, an international body, a journalist, and the world all move on evidence, not indignation. Build your file in three layers, and keep it safe.

Layer 1: The Concession, the Consultation, and the Legality

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **concession, the permits, and the law** that authorised the project, and scrutinise them: were they granted lawfully, with debate, or rushed through as the canal law was? Establish **whether the indigenous and Afro-descendant communities were consulted and consented**, as the constitution and international law require — because a bypassed or coerced consultation is a central flaw. The consultation right is worth understanding precisely, because it is one of the strongest legal footings a Nicaraguan community has, and one the international bodies take seriously. Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples are entitled, under the constitution and under international conventions the state has ratified, to be consulted freely, in advance, and with full information before a project affects their territory, and to give or withhold their consent; a consultation that never happened, or that was extracted under pressure from a co-opted authority, is a violation that persists no matter what the project's backers claim. Establishing that violation clearly gives a case a foundation that endures before the courts and the world. Document the **project's weaknesses** — its financing, its feasibility, its legality — because, as with the canal, those may prove decisive. The gap between what the concession claims and what the law and the communities' rights require is where many Nicaraguan cases are grounded. Establishing the consultation failure is especially important, because it is both a legal violation and a moral one that resonates far beyond the courtroom. The canal concession was granted over indigenous and Afro-descendant territories whose peoples had a right, under the constitution and under international conventions the state had ratified, to be consulted freely and fully beforehand — and that right was bypassed, with a territorial government reportedly pressured into signing a consent it had no real freedom to refuse. Documenting clearly who was not consulted, and how any consent was obtained, exposes a wrong that courts, international bodies, and the public all recognise.

Layer 2: The Harm to the Land, the Water, and the Lake

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **land, the water, and the great lake** at the centre. Record the **harm** — the land expropriated, the communities displaced, the lake and rivers threatened, the forests lost — that the project would cause. Document what the communities **stand to lose**: their land, their livelihood, their heritage. Photograph and date it, safely. Record **testimony** from the campesinos, the indigenous and Afro-descendant communities, and those who know the land and water. This is the human case that unites the communities and moves the nation and the world.

Layer 3: The Rights, the Harm, and the Weakness

Finally, document the case. Was there **no lawful consultation or consent**? Is the **concession unconstitutional or unlawful**? Is the **harm** to land, water, and the lake real and grave? Is the **project weak** in its own foundations? Each is a separate ground — for the courts, the international bodies, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away and that endures when the streets are closed. This is the layer that most often decides Nicaraguan fights over the long run, because here a project sold as lawful and consented is revealed to have bypassed consent, to rest on a questionable concession, to threaten the land and the lake, and to be weak at its core — exactly the case the anti-canal movement and its lawyers built. The strength of assembling all four grounds together — the missing consent, the unlawful concession, the harm, and the project's weakness — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the missing consent and the unlawful concession are the legal and international core, the harm is what unites the communities and the nation, and the weakness is what allows a project to be delayed and outlasted while the slower claims proceed. A community that documents only one leaves levers unused; one that documents all four arms every front at once, from the courtroom to the international body to the press to the diaspora, from a single well-kept and safely-stored file.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Nicaraguan cases, and where to obtain them — safely. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the missing consultation, the harm, and the project's weakness.

The Concession, the Consultation, and the Paper Trail

- **The concession and the law** — how the project was authorised, and whether lawfully.
- **The consultation record** — whether the indigenous and Afro-descendant communities were consulted and consented, the central rights question.
- **The permits and approvals** — and whether proper process was followed.
- **The project's weaknesses** — its financing, feasibility, and legality, which may prove decisive.

- **The company** — the concession-holder, foreign or domestic, and its record and resources.

How to Get Them

The concession and the law are matters of public record; the consultation record through the communities, their territorial governments, and what access allows; the project's weaknesses through the press, the technical and financial record, and expert allies. Lean on **allies**: Nicaragua's public-interest and environmental lawyers, the indigenous and Afro-descendant territorial authorities, the universities and churches where they can still act, the independent press, and — crucially now — the **diaspora and international networks** that can gather and hold what is dangerous to hold inside the country. Move carefully: gather and store evidence in ways that protect the people who provide it, because in today's Nicaragua documentation itself can carry risk. The discipline of safe documentation is not paranoia but prudence, and it should be built into a campaign from the first day: gather evidence discreetly, avoid exposing witnesses whose testimony could bring reprisal, keep copies in more than one place and, wherever possible, outside the country with trusted allies or the diaspora, so that a raid or a seizure cannot destroy the record or turn it into a weapon against those who made it. A community that documents boldly but stores carelessly can hand the state both the erasure of its case and the identification of its people; one that documents and protects with equal care keeps its truth safe and its people safer.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — the land taken, the communities displaced, the water and lake threatened, dated and documented safely.
- **The missing consultation** — who was and was not consulted, and how consent was bypassed or coerced.
- **The project's weakness** — the financing gaps, the delays, the infeasibility.
- **The communities' claim** — the ownership, the rights, the sovereignty.
- **Testimony** — from campesinos, indigenous and Afro-descendant communities, gathered and stored safely.

Organise It So It Persuades — and Protect It

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the consultation, the harm, the project's weakness, and every step of the fight — the spine of any legal or international case. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a campesino, a lawyer, a journalist, a judge, and an international body all see the same clear picture fast, and it endures when the streets are closed. But in Nicaragua, add a further discipline: **protect the record and the people in it**, storing evidence securely, including outside the country through the diaspora and international allies, so that what is gathered cannot be seized or used against those who gathered it. In a country where the fight must often move abroad, the community with the better-kept and better-protected record — above all the clearest proof of the missing consultation and the project's weakness — is very often the one whose claim survives.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE COMMUNITIES AND THE ALLIANCE

Evidence and rights do not win on their own. Organised people do — and in Nicaragua, the anti-canal movement proved that organised campesinos, allied with indigenous and Afro-descendant communities, can deny a megaproject its legitimacy. But it also proved the terrible cost, so a modern campaign must organise for strength and for safety together. A Nicaraguan campaign's power is that organisation: the communities, the alliance across peoples, and, increasingly, the networks beyond the state's reach.

Phase 1: The Core and the Communities

Start with a committed core rooted in the **affected communities** — the campesinos, and the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples whose land and rights are at stake. Build the **community assembly** as the base of decision and legitimacy, as the anti-canal movement built its councils. Assign roles — documentation, legal liaison, alliance-building, media, and, vitally, **security and the protection of those who lead**. Agree on the goal — the project denied, delayed, exposed, or outlasted, and the land held — and on how to organise while keeping people safe.

Phase 2: The Broad Alliance

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **indigenous and Afro-descendant communities**, whose rights to consultation and whose territorial authority are both a claim and a strength, as the Rama, the Kriol, and others stood against the canal; the

wider campesino movement, so the countryside speaks as one; the **churches, universities, and civil society** where they can still act; the **independent press**; and — essential now — the **diaspora, the international human-rights networks, and the inter-American system**, which can act where those inside cannot. The anti-canal movement drew its power from exactly this breadth — a united countryside, the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, lawyers, the press, and international attention — which is precisely the spread a Nicaraguan campaign, now more than ever, needs. The alliance across peoples was not incidental to the canal fight but central to it, because the route ran the width of the country, from the Pacific campesino zones to the Caribbean territories of the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, and only a movement that united them all could speak for the whole line the canal would cut. That breadth gave the resistance both legitimacy and reach, and it is a model worth holding onto: a project that divides communities can be beaten by communities that refuse to be divided, and that add to one another's numbers the distinct legal rights that each people holds.

A worked alliance example. Facing a concession over their land, the campesino communities form the base and the assemblies; the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples add their rights and authority; the lawyers mount the constitutional and international case; the press and diaspora carry the story; and the international bodies apply the scrutiny. No single group could carry it; together they cover the land, the rights, the law, and the world — the model the anti-canal movement built. What is striking about that model is how much of its strength came from breadth rather than from any single powerful actor: no one group among the campesinos, the indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, the lawyers, the journalists, or the international allies could have stopped the canal alone, but together they made the project a contested national and international cause that never escaped controversy. A community should therefore invest early in building the widest coalition it safely can, because it is the breadth of the alliance, more than the strength of any one part, that gives a Nicaraguan campaign its resilience and its reach.

Phase 3: Sustaining It — and Protecting It

Campaigns die of burnout, or worse — and a Nicaraguan fight now runs through danger. Meet safely and on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the missing consultation documented, an alliance sealed, a legal filing, an international hearing, a wave of coverage. Keep the communities united and the alliance broad, and guard against the **division and the repression** — the co-optation of a territorial government, the targeting of leaders, the fear sown to break the movement — that the powerful will use. Above all, **protect the people**: plan for the safety of those who lead and testify, know the risks, and build the networks, including abroad, that can carry the fight if those inside are silenced. The anti-canal movement endured in exile and in prison because it was more than its leaders; build that resilience in from the start.

Phase 4: Acting Wisely

Where there is an opening, numbers and unity make the community's stand visible — the assembly, the peaceful march, the documented refusal — as the anti-canal movement made its stand through a hundred marches. But in today's Nicaragua, judge the danger with the utmost care: open protest can bring grave repression, and a wise campaign weighs when visible action serves the cause and when the fight is better carried through the courts, the international bodies, the press, and the diaspora. The point is not spectacle, and it is not to expose people to harm; it is to demonstrate — by whatever means are safe — that the communities are united, that their rights were violated, and that the project is contested and will be outlasted, as the canal was, while protecting the people who carry the fight.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE CONSTITUTION, THE COURTS, AND INTERNATIONAL BODIES

Nicaragua's courts are heavily constrained, but the law — the constitution, the rights to consultation, and, above all, the international and inter-American systems — remains a real lever, and often the most important one when the streets are closed. You do not need a domestic court victory to win: a documented illegality, an established rights violation, an international ruling, or a project outlasted can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and international allies early — but understand the tools.

The Constitution and Consultation

The first lever is the **constitution and the right to consultation**. The canal challenge, brought by a lawyer and scores of plaintiffs, argued that the concession violated the constitution, and that the indigenous and Afro-descendant communities' right to **free, prior, and informed consultation** — affirmed by the constitution and by international law — was bypassed. Establish the missing or coerced consultation and the constitutional violations, and mount the challenge;

even in constrained courts, the documented illegality is a lasting claim that matters at home and abroad.

The Courts and the Record

The second lever is the **courts and the record**. Nicaragua's courts are constrained and often will not deliver, but a **filed case builds a documented, sworn record** of the illegality and the harm — a record that endures, that supports the international case, and that stands ready for a day when the courts are freer. Use the courts too where a project's own process was flawed. Do not expect them to save you, but do not neglect the record they create. There is a real and often underappreciated value in filing even a case you expect to lose at home: the pleadings, the sworn testimony, and the evidence entered become a formal, dated record of the illegality and the harm, one that cannot easily be erased and that can be carried into the international forums and held for a future in which the domestic courts may be freer. The canal challenge, brought by a lawyer and scores of plaintiffs, did exactly this — it put the constitutional objections and the communities' rights on the record in a way that outlived the moment, and a community should see litigation partly as an act of documentation that endures.

International and Inter-American Bodies

The third lever, and the decisive one when the domestic space is closed, is the **international and inter-American human-rights system**. The **Inter-American Commission and Court of Human Rights**, the **United Nations bodies**, and international human-rights and environmental networks can **document, scrutinise, and rule** on violations the domestic system will not touch — the bypassed consultation, the repression, the dispossession. These bodies cannot always compel a government, but their scrutiny, their rulings, and the record they create are real pressure and a lasting vindication, and they are reachable by the diaspora when those inside cannot act. This is the crucial shift a community must grasp about fighting in today's Nicaragua: when the domestic courts will not rule and the streets are too dangerous, the centre of gravity of a campaign moves outward, to the bodies and the people beyond the state's control. The inter-American human-rights system in particular has become a vital forum for Nicaraguan cases, one that can hear what domestic courts will not, issue findings the government cannot simply suppress, and keep a violation on the international record for years. A community that builds its ties to these bodies, through lawyers and the diaspora, secures a channel that repression at home cannot close.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Constitutional and consultation claims go through the **courts** and the communities' **territorial authorities**; the enduring record through the **filed case and sworn testimony**; and the decisive pressure, when the space is closed, through the **inter-american and international bodies and the diaspora**. Get help early: Nicaragua's public-interest lawyers, the indigenous and Afro-descendant authorities, and the international and inter-American networks know the law and the routes. Help engaged early — and, crucially, allies placed beyond the reach of domestic repression — is worth far more than help sought after, and in Nicaragua the strongest strategy marries the **communities and their rights** below to the **international bodies** above, with the **documented record** as the thread that ties them and endures.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, an international body, a journalist, the diaspora, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once, especially when the domestic space is closed.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a concession was granted over indigenous and campesino land, in days and without the free, prior, and informed consultation the constitution requires, for a project whose foreign backer had no secure financing. That one fact becomes:

- **A constitutional argument:** the concession violated the constitution and the right to consultation — the case before the courts.
- **An international argument:** the state breached its obligations on indigenous consultation and consent — the case before the inter-American and UN bodies.
- **A sovereignty argument:** the nation's land was signed away to a foreign company without the people's consent — the case that unites the country.
- **A feasibility argument:** the project was never viable, its backer never able — the case that exposes and outlasts it.

- **A public and diaspora argument:** our land was to be taken and we were never asked — the case that moves the nation and the world.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Nicaragua the arguments that most often endure are the **consultation-and-constitution** one, because it grounds the legal and international case, and the **sovereignty-and-dispossession** one, because it unites the nation. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the concession record and a claim made to an international body can be proven by the consultation facts; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive, and vital when the fight is fought in many places at once.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the violation framed against the constitution and the law, with the concession and consultation records that prove it.

The international and inter-american bodies want the breach of consultation, consent, and rights framed against the state's obligations, with the documented record.

The public and the nation respond to the sovereignty and dispossession frame: our land, our lake, our sovereignty, signed away without our consent.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: farmers in rubber boots who faced down a fifty-billion-dollar canal, or a concession that would drown a great lake.

The diaspora and international allies respond to the rights violations and the repression, and to the call to carry the fight where those inside cannot.

The communities themselves need to see the rights are real and the project is weak, so they stay united and endure, as the anti-canal communities endured.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Nicaragua, where the domestic space is closed and much of the press is exiled, the media and the diaspora are among the most important levers left. Coverage denies a project legitimacy, brings in international pressure, protects those who resist by making their fate visible, and carries the fight beyond the state's reach. The anti-canal movement became a national and international story precisely because it was so striking — campesinos facing down a superpower's canal.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place, a documented wrong, and a human stake. "A community opposes a project" is not a story; "a concession would drown a great lake and expropriate the land of farmers who were never consulted, for a canal whose backer had no money" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the missing consultation, the harm, the project's weakness — and offer a human voice: a campesino leader, an indigenous authority, a displaced family. In Nicaragua the story of ordinary people defending their land and sovereignty against a vast project, at great personal cost, is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Community and local voices** first, where it is safe. Then the **national independent press** — much of it now in exile, but still reaching the country. Then, crucially, the **international and diaspora ring** — the foreign press, the international human-rights and environmental networks, and the Nicaraguan diaspora — because when the domestic space is closed, the international and diaspora attention is what applies pressure, protects people, and carries the cause. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international and diaspora ring is especially decisive** in Nicaragua now, because it operates beyond the reach of domestic repression.

Sustain It, and Keep It True and Safe

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Nicaraguan fight runs for years, often from exile. Plan a sequence — the concession, the missing consultation, the harm, the challenge, the repression, the project's weakness — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; in a context of repression and propaganda, precision protects the movement's credibility, and any exaggeration will be seized upon. And protect your sources and people: tell the story in ways that do not expose those still inside to greater danger. Verified, specific, sovereignty-and-rights-centred, safe, and carried to the world — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped campesinos make the world watch a canal.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you assert, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the courts, the government, the international bodies, and the press and diaspora. Each does double duty: it asks or asserts something and it documents that you did. Keep copies of everything, stored safely including abroad, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the rights, the harm, and the project's weakness — and mindful of the safety of those who send them.

8A. Assertion of Rights and Objection (to the Government)

To: the relevant authority **Subject:** Objection to [concession/project] over the land of [communities]

We, the communities of [place], object to [concession/project], granted over our land without the **free, prior, and informed consultation** the constitution and international law require. We assert our rights to our land and to consultation, and we call for [the project's suspension / the consultation owed / the concession's review]. We attach our evidence and reserve all legal and international remedies.

8B. Constitutional / Legal Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the courts (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to [concession/law] as unconstitutional

On behalf of the communities of [place], we challenge [concession/law] as **unconstitutional** and in violation of the right to consultation and consent. The concession was granted [without proper process / without consultation / unlawfully], as the attached record shows. We seek [its annulment / suspension] and the protection of the communities' rights.

8C. Appeal to the Inter-American / International Bodies

To: the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights / a UN body **Subject:** Rights violations from [project] against [communities]

We bring to your attention the violations arising from [project]: the **bypassed consultation and consent** of indigenous and Afro-descendant communities, the threatened **dispossession**, and [any repression of those who resist]. We attach our documented record and request [examination / precautionary measures / a hearing], as the domestic remedies are [exhausted / unavailable].

8D. Environmental / Lake-and-Land Harm Complaint

To: the environmental authority / an international body **Subject:** Harm to land, water, and [the lake] from [project]

We, the communities of [place], report that [project] would [drown our land / threaten the great lake / destroy the forests], documented and attached. We call for the protection of our environment and the halting of the project, in keeping with the law and the communities' rights.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Rights Organisation

To: a public-interest lawyer / human-rights organisation **Subject:** [Project] — rights, consultation, and the record

We are defending [land/communities] from [project]. We attach the concession and consultation records, our evidence of harm, and our account of the project's weaknesses, and seek advice on the **constitutional challenge**, the **international appeal**, and the **protection of our people**. Please advise on the strongest ground, the deadlines, and how to proceed

safely.

8F. Appeal to the Diaspora / International Networks

To: [diaspora network / international human-rights or environmental organisation] **Subject:** Carry the fight for [land/communities] against [project]

We write from [place / exile] regarding [project], which threatens [our land, our lake, our people]. As the anti-canal movement carried its cause to the world, we ask you to help **document, amplify, and pressure** from beyond the reach of those who would silence us. We attach our case and can connect you, safely, with our communities and leaders.

8G. Email to a Reporter (Independent / International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the land / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something the world should know, with a clear hook: [documents and testimony] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a concession would drown a great lake and expropriate farmers who were never consulted, for a project whose backer had no financing"]. It echoes the canal fight. I can share our documented file and connect you, safely, with a campesino leader and an indigenous authority. Could we talk securely this week?

8H. Public / Community Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** We defend [our land / our lake / our sovereignty]

We, the communities of [place], declare that we will defend [our land, our lake, our sovereignty]. [Project] would [take our land without our consent / drown our lake / sign away our sovereignty], and we were never consulted. As the campesinos and peoples of Nicaragua faced down a canal, we will use our unity, our rights, the courts, the world, and the diaspora to defend what is ours, and we will not relent — even from exile, even in the face of fear.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, log every one in your timeline, and store copies safely including abroad — the record of an objection, a legal filing, or an international appeal is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the international bodies, and the world will heed, and it endures when the domestic space is closed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the rights, the harm, and the project's weakness; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the communities, the lawyers, the international networks, and the diaspora. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in Nicaragua that record feeds the levers that matter most now: the constitutional and consultation claims, the international bodies, and the enduring documented truth that no repression can erase.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign, and in Nicaragua not everyone can safely protest. With a few hours a week you can still defend your land and build a lasting case — often more safely than through the streets. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Document the missing consultation and the harm.** Establish that the communities were not consulted and record what the project would destroy (Step 2). This is always possible and always valuable.
- 2. Establish the project's weakness.** Find where the project is fragile — its money, its legality, its feasibility (Step 1).
- 3. Unite the communities and the alliance — safely.** Build the assemblies and the alliance across peoples, protecting those who lead (Step 3).
- 4. Assert your rights and object.** Put the objection and the rights claim on the record (8A).
- 5. Reach a lawyer and the international bodies.** Mount the constitutional challenge and the inter-American appeal (8B, 8C, 8E).
- 6. Reach the diaspora and the world.** Carry the fight beyond the state's reach (8F, 8G).

7. Protect your people and your record. Store evidence safely, including abroad, and guard those who resist.

Do only the first three and you will have documented the wrong, found the project's weakness, and united the communities safely — the foundation of a Nicaraguan land defence today. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: document, find the weakness, unite safely.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Nicaragua's system is tilted in severe ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort, nor miss the levers that work, nor expose your people to needless danger.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is not subtle; it is severe. Power is **highly concentrated**, and concessions can be granted in days with little debate, as the canal law was. The **courts are constrained** and often will not rule against the government. **Consultation rights are affirmed but bypassed**, as they were for the indigenous communities in the canal's path. And, most gravely, **open dissent brings severe repression** — the anti-canal leaders were imprisoned, exiled, and killed, and the civic space has since closed almost entirely. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes fair courts, safe protest, or an open press will be not only disappointed but endangered.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this severe tilt, real levers remain — though they must be used wisely.

The documented record still endures. No repression erases a well-kept, safely-stored record of the illegality, the missing consultation, and the harm.

The communities' rights still stand. The right to consultation and consent, though violated, remains a real claim before the courts and the world.

The international bodies still reach. The inter-American and UN systems can scrutinise and rule where the domestic system will not, and the diaspora can reach them.

A project's own weakness still matters. As with the canal, a project may fall on its financing, its feasibility, its own fragility, whatever the government wills.

The world still watches. International and diaspora attention applies pressure and protects people beyond the reach of domestic repression.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Nicaragua is sober and cautious, but not without hope: the space is closed and the danger is real, but the record, the rights, the international bodies, the project's own weakness, and the world's attention still give a determined people real levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: **document** always and safely; establish the **missing consultation** and the **project's weakness**; unite the **communities** while protecting them; mount the **legal and international** case; and carry the fight through the **world and the diaspora** — while never forgetting that the first duty is to protect the people who resist, and that in today's Nicaragua much of the fight must be waged from the courts, the international bodies, and abroad rather than the streets.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Nicaragua has grave and well-documented concerns about how power and concessions are handled, so this section matters. When a concession is granted not in the public interest but to enrich the connected — signed away in days, without consultation, to a foreign backer, with sweeping powers over the people's land — your strategy includes exposing that capture.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **concession granted in haste**, with little debate and no consultation, as the canal law was; **sweeping powers** handed to a private company over the people's land; a **rubber-stamp legislature** and **constrained courts**; the **bypassing of indigenous consent**; and the **repression of those who object**. Trace the concession and the power: how it was granted, to whom, with what benefit to the connected, and at what cost to the communities and the nation. In Nicaragua, a concession signed away without consultation and defended by repression is often not a mere policy but an exercise of captured power — exactly what the anti-canal movement named when it defended land, lake, and sovereignty.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **The legislature, much of the judiciary, and the organs of the state** can be captured by concentrated power. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **inter-american and international bodies**, beyond the state's control; the **independent and exiled press**; the **diaspora**; the **international human-rights and environmental networks**; and the **communities** themselves, whose rights and record endure. Capture thrives on the communities' silence and isolation and on the world's inattention; your task is to unite the communities safely, document the capture, and carry it to the bodies and the world the state cannot reach.

What to Do

Do not assume captured power cannot be exposed or outlasted. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the concession was granted, to whom, without what consultation, at what cost — and take it to the forces that can act: the **inter-american and international bodies**, to scrutinise and rule; the **independent and exiled press and the diaspora**, to expose; and the **historical and legal record**, which endures. Pair the exposure with the communities' rights claim and the project's own weakness, so the illegitimacy and the fragility surface together. In Nicaragua, exposing how power and land are captured, and keeping the record safe and the international bodies engaged, is often the way a people's claim survives a closed system — and, as with the canal, outlasts even a megaproject.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Nicaragua now turns on the record, the rights, and the international reach as much as the community's stand.

Early (Weeks 0-16): Document, Unite Safely, Assert

Pin down the project and the communities' rights (Step 1); **document** the missing consultation, the harm, and the project's weakness, and store the record safely (Step 2). Unite the **communities and the alliance**, protecting those who lead (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **assert the rights and object** (8A); reach a **lawyer and the international networks** early (8E, 8F); and prepare the **constitutional and international** case (8B, 8C). This phase lays the foundation, and in Nicaragua the safe, well-stored record and the international allies established here are what endure.

Middle (Months 4-24): Challenge, Expose, Protect

Sustain the communities' unity and safety (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Mount the **constitutional challenge** and the **international appeal** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international and diaspora (Step 5). Expose the **project's weakness** and the **captured power**. Throughout, **protect the people**. Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — documenting and filing before evidence is lost or people are silenced — because those chances may not return.

Later (Months 12-48+): Endure, and Outlast

Pursue what is achievable — the project **denied, delayed, exposed, or outlasted**, the concession challenged, the rights vindicated, the record preserved. And endure: as the anti-canal movement endured through prison and exile until the concession was finally repealed, a Nicaraguan fight may be won by outlasting a project and a moment. Stay vigilant, because a repealed concession can be revived under a new name. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped. Often, in Nicaragua, it is a project outlasted, a rights violation recorded before the world, and a community's claim kept alive through the hardest years. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-16 Document (safely) | Unite communities + alliance | Assert rights | Reach lawyers + international allies
MONTHS 4-24 Constitutional + international challenge | Expose weakness + capture | Media + diaspora | Protect people
MONTHS 12-48+ Endure and outlast | Preserve the record | Guard against a revived concession

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Nicaragua gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and the grave limits and dangers around them.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Organised communities**, joined in an **alliance across campesino, indigenous, and Afro-descendant peoples**, can deny a megaproject its legitimacy, as they denied the canal. The **sovereignty and anti-dispossession frame** unites the nation. The **rights to consultation and consent**, and the **constitutional challenge**, ground a lasting legal and international case. A project's **own weakness** can be decisive. And when the domestic space closes, the **international and inter-american bodies, the diaspora, and the enduring record** carry the fight beyond the state's reach. These are the tools that let farmers in rubber boots help face down a fifty-billion-dollar canal. They are, importantly, tools that depend on organisation, rights, and endurance rather than on wealth or power, which is why they remained available to some of the poorest communities in the country against one of the largest projects ever proposed — and why, used wisely and safely, they remain available even now.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them without flinching. The canal fell as much on its **backer's collapse** as on the resistance. Open protest brings **severe repression** — imprisonment, exile, death. And the **civic space has closed** almost entirely. No guide should pretend these away; in Nicaragua, the art is to protect the people, to keep the record and the rights alive, to lean on the world and the diaspora when the streets are shut, and to outlast a project and a moment.

So the realistic promise is this: **document safely and always; establish the missing consultation and the project's weakness; unite the communities and the alliance while protecting them; mount the constitutional and international case; and carry the fight through the world and the diaspora — running all of it together, and protecting your people above all.** Do that, and where communities are united and a project is weak or unlawful, you can deny it legitimacy, expose it, and outlast it, as the canal was outlasted; where the space is closed, you can still keep the record, vindicate the rights before the world, and protect the claim through the hardest years. Do it as the anti-canal movement did — campesinos and peoples who defended their land and sovereignty, endured terrible cost, and saw the concession fall.

A last word on endurance and safety. Nicaragua's lesson is double: that a determined people, united across campesino, indigenous, and Afro-descendant communities, holds more power than the powerful want it to believe — that farmers in rubber boots can help stop a canal — but that the price can be terrible, and that the first duty of a movement is to protect its people and preserve its truth. The powerful count on your fear, your isolation, and the closing of the space. Their advantage is the concentrated power, the constrained courts, and the repression. Yours is the unity of the communities, the rights that endure, the record no repression can erase, the international bodies beyond the state's reach, the diaspora that carries on, and the proven fact that a great canal was faced down and finally fell. The diaspora deserves a particular word, because it has become one of the most important assets a Nicaraguan cause can have: a large community abroad, including many of the very leaders and journalists driven into exile, that can organise, document, litigate, and campaign in freedom, reaching the international bodies and the world's press on behalf of those who cannot. A community fighting a project at home should build its ties to that diaspora deliberately, entrusting it with the record, the story, and the international work, so that the fight has a base beyond the reach of any repression at home. Play to that. Keep the record safe, keep the communities united and protected, ground the fight in rights and sovereignty, reach the world and the diaspora, and treat every documented wrong, every filing, every international hearing, and every year a project is outlasted as a stone in a wall that even a closed system cannot easily pull down.

The tools are here, and Nicaragua itself proved them, at terrible cost: campesinos and indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples who united to defend their land, their lake, and their sovereignty, documented the wrong, carried it to the world, endured prison and exile, and saw a fifty-billion-dollar canal come to nothing and its concession repealed. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the unity of the communities, the endurance to outlast a project and a moment, the truth kept safe, the world engaged — and, above all, the protection of the people who fight. Begin today, begin with your safe documentation and your united communities, protecting your people as you go, and build patiently from there. Communities before you have defended their land and sovereignty and outlasted a megaproject, at great cost and with great courage — a canal faced down, a concession repealed after years of struggle, a claim kept alive through prison, exile, and the closing of the space. What Nicaragua's campesinos won can be won again, by a people organised, patient,

protected, and unbroken. So can yours. A people of modest means, who united across the country, defended their land and their great lake, carried their cause to the courts and the world, and endured prison and exile until the concession they fought was struck down, have shown what is possible from below even against concentrated power; the organisation, the rights, the record, and the reach into the world are the method, and the proof that it can be done, at real cost and with real care for the people who fight, is now yours to take up.